limited to a few hours. The military commanders seized the opportunity but failed to take advantage of it. Because of the time difference between Nicaragua and Cuba, the planes arrived later than expected. Two of them were shot down, and four American pilots went missing. Radio Havana declared that the Cubans had recovered the body of one of the Americans. By now the venture had turned into a complete disaster.[19]

Kennedy would never again authorize even limited use of the US Air Force. By Thursday, April 20, it was all over. The invaders had spent two and a half days resisting the inevitable. Lacking air support, low on ammunition, outnumbered, outgunned, and increasingly demoralized, they surrendered. The casualties included more than 100 dead and more than 360 wounded; close to 1,200 were taken prisoner. Castro's losses were greater, but it did not matter: neither he nor his armed forces surrendered. It was a stunning victory for Castro and his regime and an astounding defeat for Kennedy.[20]

Kennedy had lost on both fronts, militarily and politically. Political victory turned out to be impossible without a military one. In the days and months that followed, analyzing what had gone wrong with the Bay of Pigs invasion, Kennedy blamed himself first, but then went on to blame the CIA and the military, not the State Department and those who had advised him against an overt US military operation. As far as Kennedy was concerned, the CIA and the military had promised him something they could not deliver and set a trap to force him into a military operation that he did not want to authorize. "In a parliamentary government, I'd have to resign. But in this government, I can't, so you and Allen [Dulles] have to go," he told Bissell.[21]

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BEFORE THE END OF THE YEAR, BOTH BISSELL AND DULLES were gone. The chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, General Lemnitzer, who had kept insisting on an invasion of Cuba, was removed from his post in September 1962. Even though some of the key participants in the Bay of Pigs debacle left the scene, mistrust and suspicion between the president and the generals